

German company, Metro AG decided to threaten Microsoft since they had a trademark on “Metro” which Microsoft was infringing. Whether there is a chance that people would really be confused between a group running chain of stores and a design language for an operating system, we will never know because Microsoft dropped the terminology like a pernicious porcupine.

Wouldn’t it have been fun if Microsoft—after investing so much time and presumably money—developing awareness about an upcoming technology had kept it despite legal cost. If they had just bought Metro AG instead. Besides it would have been fun to see Microsoft grocery stores selling apples.

Now we come to the rather more confusing matter of what it is called now. Metro was a perfect name, a brilliant name. If you wanted to talk about the new kinds of applications in Windows 8 you would call them Metro apps; if you wanted to talk about the new UI in Window 8 you would call it Metro, and if you wanted to talk about the design philosophy behind the Windows 8 UI, you would call it the Metro design language. With that one term out of the picture, things fall apart.

One could simply replace the term Metro with another term, say “Nutero”, but you see now one knows what Nutero is, and it doesn’t have as much brand value as Metro did. If they had called it that from the start, things would have been fine, probably.

However it is also important to consider the fact that Metro was essentially Microsoft’s term for the new design language used by Windows 8. It was a style of designing application interfaces. When people call the new Windows 8 applications Metro-style apps or Metro apps, that is not accurate. Since there may be Windows 8 applications that are not designed with the Metro design principles in mind. So now we call them Windows 8 apps, or Windows Store apps, since the only way to get them is via the Windows Store. If we have to be really pedantic we can point out that it is entirely possible to follow the Metro design principles and make an app for the Windows desktop or even Linux—in fact it is currently possible to run the Metro version of Firefox on Windows 7, or Linux.

In referring to the design of Windows 8, it is easy enough to just call it the Windows 8 UI. For a while Microsoft was calling it Modern UI, and that is a term we have used in this booklet in many places as well.

As for the design language itself, Microsoft now seems to be calling it the Microsoft design language in their developer documentation.

So now we know what the Metro name was used for, and that it was a design language; we will now refer to it as Modern UI. What we intend